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UAE Presidential Court

MOHAMED MEETS PRESIDENT OF IRAQ'S KURDISTAN REGION

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan received Nechirvan Barzani, President of the Kurdistan Region of Iraq. During the meeting, the leaders discussed cooperation between the UAE and the Republic of Iraq, including the Kurdistan Region, and ways to expand it in a manner that supports mutual interests and benefits both peoples. They also exchanged views on issues of mutual interest, particularly regional developments and their serious implications for regional and international security and stability.

UAE launches instant bank account service for tourists

New CBUAE, ICP, ADCB service lets tourists open accounts on arrival

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

The Central Bank of the UAE (CBUAE), in partnership with the Federal Authority for Identity, Citizenship, Customs and Port Security (ICP) and Abu Dhabi Commercial Bank (ADCB), has introduced a new service allowing tourists to open bank accounts digitally upon arrival in the country.

The initiative, called the "Tourist Identity", enables non-resident visitors to set up a bank account within minutes using a secure digital

Tourists can open a bank account instantly, access a digital debit card for immediate use, and start using banking services without paperwork.

identity issued at entry. Visitors receive a digital identity when they arrive in the UAE. This identity is powered by biometric and facial recognition technology developed by ICP.

Fully digital

By linking this system to ADCB's mobile banking app, tourists can open a bank account instantly, access a digital debit card for immediate use, and start using banking services without paperwork. The process is fully digital and

does not require traditional documents.

The service removes a common barrier for visitors who need access to local banking during their stay. You can pay digitally instead of relying on cash, manage expenses more easily during travel, and access secure banking services from day one. This is particularly useful for longer stays, business travel, or frequent visitors.

Saif Humaid Al Dhaheri of the CBUAE said the initiative helps create "an integrated and secure banking experience for visitors from the moment they arrive."

ICP said the Tourist Identity system is built on advanced biometric verification and artificial intelligence. The aim is to allow visitors to access services across sectors without needing to present physical documents.

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Pakistan brings down passport delivery time from 21 to 14 days | P4

BUSINESS
My Business: Dubai duo bets on what restaurants throw away | P8

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OIL SWINGS WILDLY AS US-IRAN TENSIONS RISE

Analysts warn Brent crude could test \$150

DUBAI
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

Brent crude retreated to around \$114 a barrel after briefly surging above \$125 yesterday, but traders and consumers remain on edge as the US blockade of the Strait of Hormuz keeps global energy supplies under pressure.

The pullback did little to ease concerns in energy markets, with prices still far above pre-conflict levels of around \$70 per barrel and reflecting persistent fears of supply disruption and geopolitical escalation.

US President Donald Trump told *Axios* that the blockade would continue until Iran agrees to a deal with Washington over its nuclear programme. "The blockade is somewhat more effective than the bombing. They are choking like a stuffed pig. And it is going to be worse for them. They can't have a nuclear weapon," Trump said, according to the report.

Supply risks drive volatility

The Strait of Hormuz is a critical route for global oil and gas shipments, and any prolonged disruption can quickly feed into crude prices, freight costs, insurance premiums and inflation.

Benchmark US crude also eased to about \$104.51 a barrel after earlier gains, underscoring the sharp intraday swings driven by geopolitical headlines.

Vijay Valecha, Chief Investment Officer at Century Financial, said the risk of another spike has increased, though extreme levels are not inevitable. "Although a surge to \$150 or \$200 levels is not a given, it

TRUMP: UAE'S OPEC EXIT MAY LOWER OIL PRICES

US President Donald Trump has welcomed the UAE's decision to leave Opec, saying the move could help bring down oil and fuel prices at a time when the Iran war has kept energy markets under pressure.

"I think it's great," Trump told reporters at the White House on Wednesday when asked about the UAE's decision.

"I think ultimately it's a good thing for getting the price of gas down, getting oil down, getting everything down," he added. "They're having some problems in Opec."

The UAE announced on Tuesday that it will leave the Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and the wider Opec+ alliance effective today. The decision ends nearly six decades of UAE participation in coordinated oil production policy and gives the country more freedom to set output based on its own capacity plans and market conditions.

—N. D.

\$70
a barrel was the price of Brent crude prior to the war

remains a possibility and would depend heavily on updates from both the US and Iran," he said. "A major breakdown of diplomatic efforts or military escalations, with the Strait of Hormuz remaining closed, could be the next catalyst for another oil spike."

Valecha said Brent, already above \$120 before its pullback, could move to \$150 "within a matter of 2 weeks" if similar price patterns repeat, while a more severe supply deficit could bring \$200 into view within six to eight weeks.

Fuel costs rise locally

Economist Jeffrey Sachs warned of wider economic damage. "The world economy will suffer a terrible crisis," he said, if shortages are not eased. For consumers, the immediate

concern is whether elevated crude prices will continue feeding into fuel costs, transport expenses and broader inflation in the coming months.

Petrol prices in the UAE rose at a slower pace in May, compared to a sharper rise in April. Super 98 and Special 95 are up by 27 fils each this month, respectively, after jumping by about 80 fils in April. E-Plus rose by 28 fils to Dh3.48 after an earlier increase of roughly 35 fils, while diesel remains unchanged after surging by nearly Dh1.97 in April.

Dat Tong, Senior Financial Markets Strategist at Exness, said prices could keep rising worldwide if disruption persists. "Oil prices could continue to climb towards the \$150 level if the disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz persist for an extended period and hopes of a resolution decline," he said.

Ole Hansen, Head of Commodity Strategy at Saxo Bank, said the market needs a clear reopening signal to reverse. "Oil will rise several dollars every day as long as there is no end in sight," he said.

SEE ALSO P2, 6, 7, 11, 13

UAE foils bid to route weapons to Port Sudan

13 suspects and 6 firms referred to State Security Court

ABU DHABI
BY AGHADDIR ALI
Senior Reporter

The UAE Attorney-General has referred 13 defendants and six companies to the State Security Court on charges linked to an alleged attempt to transit military materiel through the country to Port Sudan.

Counsellor Dr Hamad Saif Al Shamsi said the case, now before the Abu Dhabi Federal Court of Appeal (State Security Court), involves accusations of illicit arms trafficking, forgery of official documents and money laundering. According to the Public Prosecution, investigations revealed that the network sought to move a consignment of ammunition through UAE territory in violation of national laws and regula-

INDIVIDUALS AND FIRMS FACING ACTION

Defendants

- Rashed Omar Abdul Qader Ali
- Mohammed Al Fath Mohammed Beik
- Salah Abdallah Mohammed Saleh
- Abdullah Khalafallah
- Ahmed Rabie Sayed Ahmed Mohammed
- Yasser Abdulrahman Hassan Al Atta
- Othman Mohammed Al Zubair Mohammed
- Maher Abduljalil Mohammed Abduljalil
- Khaled Yousef Mukhtar Yousef
- Ahmed Khalafallah Abdullah

tions. Authorities said the operation was uncovered and stopped before completion, with suspects arrested and shipments tracked.

Prosecutors said the case is tied to procurement arrangements linked to the Port Sudan Authority, with coordination al-

- Ahmed
- Mubarak Ali Al Sheikh Mohammed
- Othman Bakr Ali Karrar
- Musab Awad Al Karim Hassan Mohammed

Companies

- Rashed Omar Brokerage Company
- Portex Trade Limited
- Wardat Al Masarra Trading Company
- Sudamina Company
- Yellow Sand Trading Company
- Apollara Electronics Trading Company

legedly carried out by individuals connected to the deal.

Investigators found that the scheme involved two interconnected transactions designed to conceal its illegal nature through commercial and financial fronts.

The first deal, concluded

outside the UAE, involved an agreement to supply weapons — including Kalashnikov rifles, machine guns and grenades — with a declared value of \$13 million, while the actual value was estimated at no more than \$10 million. The difference, authorities allege, was distributed as illicit commissions among those involved, using UAE-based companies and bank accounts as cover.

The second transaction took place inside the UAE, where more than \$2 million from the proceeds of the first deal was used to procure additional ammunition. Part of this shipment was brought into the country using fraudulent methods, including transport via a private aircraft, in preparation for onward transfer.

Evidence gathered includes seized financial and commercial records, bank transfer data, correspondence, and recorded communications, alongside confessions from several defendants, prosecutors said.



SPORT

Kimi Antonelli aims for a hat-trick of wins in Miami
Mercedes driver hopes to continue dominance | P14